CROSSING OVER

BASED ON THE OUTGOING BALENO HATCHBACK, INSPIRED BY THE GRAND VITARA, HOW IS THE NEW FRONX AS A STANDALONE PRODUCT?

BY ABHIK DAS



HARVINDER SINGH

The unusual name, I presume, is a derivative from its classification as a front-wheel-drive crossover but once past the name, the Fronx comes across as a truly handsome-looking compact SUV that makes its purpose very evident.

You see, the Grand Vitara right now sits atop the Nexa portfolio as the brand's flagship SUV debuting a strong hybrid powertrain and focusing on meeting the increasing demands of the form factor as well as high fuel efficiency needs. The SUV's form factor is what far supersedes demand for any other type of car, especially in a segment of vehicles that caps off under the Rs 15 lakh mark. Relatively smaller footprint, it champions the urban jungle, is fuel efficient, feature-rich and adds a dash of premium to complete the recipe for a compact SUV that the Fronx is. For Maruti, this means retaining a family face from its premium SUV thus explaining the easily recognisable styling of the Fronx.

Inside the cabin, the space feels absolutely familiar being a straight lift from the Baleno and offers an opportunity for Maruti Suzuki to re-emphasise the cliché — why fix it if it ain't broke. Good quality materials and upholstery aside, the interior does offer room for four adults easily with the scope of a fifth passenger fitting into the rear seat. The features get carried forward too. So, seamless connectivity through a 9-inch touchscreen and SmartPlay Pro+ infotainment, automatic climate control, an HUD and a 360-degree camera are all available in the top-end trim while even adding a wireless charger into the mix.

Engine
1.0-litre, 3-cyl, turbo-petrol
Power
100bhp@5,500rpm
Max torque
148Nm@2,000rpm

On the road, the Fronx again has a sense of familiarity in the way it drives as it shares the underpinnings of the Heartect platform-based Baleno. The new 1.0-litre turbo-petrol motor producing 100bhp and 148Nm is exciting especially as the power delivery is staggered and that's afforded by the turbocharger. Power comes in post 2,000rpm after a bit of lag off the line but once on the boil, 3,000-5,000rpm is where the meat of the power lies which in day-to-day usage translates to a solid mid-range if the gearbox is worked with accordingly.

The stiffened suspension and the more-than-generous 190mm of ground clearance that the Fronx rides on make it an even more capable performer when one runs out of roads entirely. The suspension, though stiff, still manages a comfortable ride quality that's versatile enough to tackle rough roads as well as smooth, flowing tarmac without upsetting the occupants or displaying excessive body roll.

The Fronx should draw a younger, more premium customer who may not require the added space in the Brezza. The compact SUV isn't rewriting the rules or setting new benchmarks in any respect but it sure brings Maruti Suzuki into a very competitive space going up against the likes of the Hyundai Venue and Kia Sonnet, among others. ■